

Name: _____

Date: _____

The Great Barrier Reef

Year 4 reading comprehension · Information text · 14 marks · About 20 minutes

A giant reef

Off the coast of Queensland lies the Great Barrier Reef, the biggest coral reef system on Earth. It stretches for about 2,300 kilometres, and it is so large that it can be seen from space. It is also very important to Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples. They have cared for their Sea Country for many thousands of years.

Not one reef

The Great Barrier Reef is not a single reef. It is made up of more than 2,900 separate reefs and about 900 islands.

Built by tiny animals

Coral reefs are built by tiny animals called coral polyps. Each polyp is soft-bodied and only a few millimetres wide, but it makes a hard skeleton of limestone around itself. When polyps die, their skeletons stay behind, and new polyps grow on top. Over thousands of years, this builds a reef.

A home for sea life

The reef is home to an amazing variety of life, including about 1,500 kinds of fish, more than 400 kinds of coral, turtles, sharks and dolphins. On some warm nights each year, corals across the reef release millions of tiny eggs and sperm into the water at the same time. This event is called mass coral spawning. Because it is so special, it became a World Heritage Area in 1981.

Danger and care

Warm seas can make corals bleach, which means they lose their colour and may die. Scientists, rangers and tourism operators work together to protect the reef. For example, they control the numbers of coral-eating starfish and limit where boats can go. Scientists also use satellites and underwater cameras to check on the health of the corals.

1. Off the coast of which state does the Great Barrier Reef lie? (1 mark)

2. About how long is the Great Barrier Reef? (1 mark)

3. The text says warm seas can make corals “bleach”. What does “bleach” mean here? Use the rest of the sentence to help you. (2 marks)

4. How do tiny coral polyps build a reef? Use the text to explain. (2 marks)

5. The writer says, “The Great Barrier Reef is not a single reef.” Why do you think the writer made this point? (2 marks)

6. Why do you think warm seas are a danger to corals? (2 marks)

7. Number these steps 1 to 4 to show how a reef grows. (2 marks)

- ☐ New polyps grow on top of the old skeletons.
- ☐ A polyp makes a hard skeleton around itself.
- ☐ Over thousands of years, a reef forms.
- ☐ The polyp dies and its skeleton stays behind.

8. Write two sentences that sum up the most important ideas in the text. (2 marks)

Writing task: Imagine you are diving on the Great Barrier Reef. Write about what you see.
